clear writing gave no quarter to anyone hoping to take solace in the comforting platitudes of the Copenhagen interpretation. “Surely, after 62 years, we should have an exact formulation of some part of quantum mechanics?” Bell said in 1989. “[Measurement devices] should not be separated off from the rest of the world into black boxes, as if [they] were not made of atoms and not ruled by quantum mechanics.” In a talk he gave in Geneva in January 1990, Bell acknowledged that the task at hand was difficult and that his own theorem proved that there was some radical change necessary, something that physics would have to come to terms with. “I think you’re stuck with the nonlocality,” Bell told the small group who had come to hear him speak that day. “I don’t know any conception of locality which works with quantum mechanics.”

Eight months later, Bell died suddenly of a massive stroke at the age of sixty-two. Memories and tributes poured in from his colleagues and friends. “He was one of the most rigorously honest men ever, and I never met anything like it, myself. He was awesome,” Abner Shimony recalled. “Bell proved Bell’s Theorem, and no one else did, because of his character.… Of course he had a tremendous intellect. But what he had to such a superlative degree was the honesty, the tenacity to push through his questions.” “John Bell had a consuming commitment to wresting an *understanding* of the natural world from the great theories of physics,” wrote Mermin and Kurt Gottfried (a physicist who had sparred with Bell over the Copenhagen interpretation several times). “He held that a theory that merely succeeded in accounting brilliantly for data, without providing a satisfactory understanding of what it described, should be subject to stringent critical scrutiny, and if such an understanding was found to be unattainable the theory should be expected to crumble, its superficial triumphs notwithstanding.… John was truly unique in the world of physics, as a personality and as an intellect—at once scientist, philosopher, and humanist. He was a person to whom deep ideas mattered deeply. Fate has been most cruel to steal him from us when he was still so brimful of vitality.”

Bell had spent a quarter century fighting the overwhelming dominance of the Copenhagen interpretation. “Trust me, you could not do what [Bell] has done without a strong personality,” said Gisin. “He would have been destroyed.” Instead, Bell thrived—not only weakening the Copenhagen